

A SERMON OF THE PALE SEAT AND THE KEEPER OF STORES

Attend, ash-bearers. Stand beneath the cold light and listen, for the coast does not soften its stones, and neither should the heart soften its vigilance.

Fenthroner was founded in 229 AS upon the Pale Coast. Mark that year in your memory—not as a comfort, but as a warning. A seat raised beside the pallor of the sea is not raised for ease. Its walls face outward. Its watch is unending. Its silence is the silence of a drawn blade.

Fenthroner is garrisoned by 5,805 troops. Let no tongue call such a number merely a number. Each count is a burden accepted. Each count is a place kept from emptiness. Yet even with that host, Fenthroner remains outside the realm's core holdings. There is a lesson for those who dwell far from the center: the edge is not lesser because the throne does not look upon it every hour. The edge is where ruin first tests the door.

Look upon Fenthroner in the mind: a fortified coastal seat framed by the stark pallor of the Pale Coast. Its stones are watchful. Its discipline is permanent. Its breath is measured. It does not promise safety; it promises readiness. And readiness, faithful ones, is a harsher blessing than comfort. Comfort teaches the soul to sleep. Readiness teaches it to remain standing while the dark gathers beyond the walls.

Now hear the name of Ossric Ashgrove.

He is a minor figure of the Ashen Era, and his birth was in 333 AS. He serves as a quartermaster. Do not despise the keeper of stores because his work is counted in ledgers, bundles, rations, tools, and sealed rooms. The spear may glitter before the eye, but the spear is not fed by glory. Armies endure by what is measured, preserved, and placed into waiting hands.

No canonical physical details are recorded of Ossric Ashgrove. Let this absence rebuke us. We hunger to carve every servant into stone, to give every laborer a face fit for remembrance. Yet the work of a quartermaster may be known without spectacle. His canonical temperament is unrecorded. Therefore judge not the silence. The silent page is not permission for invention.

Fenthron keeps watch upon the Pale Coast. Ossric Ashgrove keeps the work of supply. One stands beyond the core; the other stands behind the line. Both remind us that endurance is built from duties accepted without applause.

So go forth: be wall where a wall is needed, *measure where measure* is needed, and let no neglected place become an open gate.